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Migration for school choice: urbanisation and rural social stratification in China

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ABSTRACT

The *peidu* trend has become prevalent in rural China in the last decade, with many rural children seen studying in urban schools accompanied by their adult family members in county capitals. Essentially, *peidu* is a practice of migration for school choice. However, unlike in the international context, this school choice phenomenon in rural China is not driven by marketisation reform, but by a strategy of the local government to achieve urbanisation. Based on questionnaires and interviews, this study reveals that *peidu* is stratified by family socioeconomic status. As the rural middle and top strata migrate out of the countryside by choosing urban schools for their children, rural schools further deteriorate and children of the most disadvantaged families are left behind in deeper struggles. Similar to school choice effects in other countries, *peidu* reinforces the rural-urban educational disparities and calls into question the urbanisation strategy in China.

KEYWORDS

School choice; urbanisation; *Peidu*; social stratification; rural-to-urban migration; China

关键词

择校; 城镇化; 陪读; 社会分层; 农村人口向城镇迁移; 中国

择校迁移：中国的城镇化与农村社会分层

摘要

近十年来，‘陪读’风潮在中国农村盛行，许多农村孩子在家庭成员的陪同下到县城的学校就读。从本质上讲，‘陪读’是一种为了择校而迁移的行为。然而，与国际案例不同的是，中国农村的这种择校现象并非由市场化改革驱动，而是由地方政府实现城镇化的策略驱动。通过问卷调查和访谈，本研究发现，陪读按家庭经济地位分层。随着农村中、上层人口为子女选择城镇学校而迁出农村，农村学校的办学条件进一步恶化，最弱势家庭的子女陷入更深的困境之中。与其他国家的择校效应类似，‘陪读’强化了城乡教育差距，使人对中国的城镇化战略提出质疑。

Introduction

School choice – whereby parents choose school for their children – has long been common across the global (Ball 2003; Wu 2012). In rural China, however, it was not prevalent until the 2010s, when village schools were closed in large number (Zhang 2019) and a strong educational desire boosted rural families' investment in education

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(Wang and Teng 2022). Over the past decade, school choice has spread to rural China with the emergence of a rural-to-urban *peidu* trend.

In rural China, an increasing number of rural families choose urban schools in county capitals for their children to receive education. Disappointed with the poor academic achievement of rural schools, many rural families abandon village schools and enrol their children in better performing urban schools in county capitals (Lei 2018; Pang et al. 2017). Indeed, urban schools still outperform rural schools because of better human resources and more effective school processes (Li, Shi, and Xue 2020; Wang et al. 2017), despite the significantly narrowed gaps in budget and school facilities (Ministry of Education 2020). Urban schools attract better teaching staff, who are more experienced and motivated and with formal training (Li, Shi, and Xue 2020). While gaps in hardware keep reducing between rural and urban schools, the essential disparities in personnel and expertise continue to persist, hence the sharp differences in student learning outcomes (Zhang et al. 2018). No doubt many rural families tend to choose urban schools in county capitals, hoping to give their children a higher starting point.

Peidu is the result of this parental school choice. The long distance between the home village and the chosen urban school makes daily commute impossible. Therefore, the rural family needs to either buy or rent an apartment near the urban school and spare at least one adult, most often the mother or a grandparent, to stay with the child in the county capital. Hence the term, *peidu*, which literally means ‘accompanying children to study’, involves rural adults relocating to urban areas to accommodate their children’s education (Chen and Liang 2015; Pang et al. 2017). Due to the relocation from rural villages to urban areas, this phenomenon appears to be largely a new form of school choice through migration conducted by rural parents.

Peidu has spread widely across rural China over the past decade. One-fourth of rural children in Yulin, Shanxi Province, were *peidu* children studying in urban primary schools in 2013 (Pang et al. 2017). In Xinyi City, Jiangsu Province (located in economically developed eastern China), 69.21% of primary students studied in urban areas in 2017 (Ding, Luo, and Wang 2019). In the village of Gang in Ping, Jiangxi, two thirds of rural families in 2020 had decided to choose the primary school in the county capital instead of the village school for their children (Zhang and Zhu 2021). In short, the literature suggests that some rural schools have lost between two fifths and two thirds of the school-aged children in their catchment areas to urban schools.

Research into *peidu* remains scarce, and the limited empirical studies of this topic have mainly discussed its impact on individuals and families, such as the effects on children’s academic performance (Long et al. 2020); on *peidu* adults’ social adaptation and parents’ marital relationships (Chen and Liang 2015; Ding, Luo, and Wang 2019); and on the families’ economic burdens (Lei 2018). The current study takes a different approach by treating *peidu* phenomenon as a form of school choice, which, as found in the international literature, is a socially stratified practice (Ball 2003; Debs and Cheung 2021). Illuminated by the school choice literature, this study investigates how family economic, cultural and social capital influence rural parents’ school choice in the form of *peidu*, and how this type of school choice further affects the educational disparities between rural and urban schools.

School choice in the international context: marketisation and social stratification

School choice has remained a popular phenomenon across the world for decades. In many countries, both developed (e.g. the United States, the United Kingdom, Sweden) and developing (e.g. Chile, Colombia, Bangladesh), school choice is an important 'top-down' educational policy under neoliberal reform (Adnett and Davies 2003; Cookson and Shapira 1997). School choice policies reflect government attempts to create a competitive educational market to replace the monopolistic state educational system, a strategy claimed to improve students' academic performance, reduce inequality and increase educational diversity (Friedman 1962; Levin and Belfield 2003). In many parts of the world, school choice is an outcome of marketisation in public education (Adnett and Davies 2003; Friedman 1962).

Contrary to the original policy intentions, empirical studies have criticised the market-based school choice reform for undermining educational equality and reinforcing social stratification, because family economic, social and cultural capital is found to be crucial in school choice (Ball 2003; Debs and Cheung 2021).

Family economic capital significantly contributes to the process and results of school choice. Economic concerns, such as uniform requirements and the cost of long commute to and from school, are important considerations influencing working-class parents' choice of schools (Lareau and Goyette 2014). More importantly, economic capital has been found to enable well-off parents to gain access to a chosen school by purchasing a nearby residence (Gabay-Egozi 2016). In contrast, low-income parents are trapped in schools within their neighbourhood (Lareau and Goyette 2014). A stronger financial condition also enables parents to send their children to extracurricular classes or arrange private tutoring to promote their children's special talents or academic test scores, in preparation for admission to talent programmes or dream schools (Roda 2017).

Cultural capital also plays critical roles in school choice. Parents who are better educated are more familiar with the educational system and the school choice market, which benefits their children's school selection (Reay 2004). Children from families with higher levels of cultural capital are more likely to pass school selection procedures, such as interviews and entrance exams (Carrasco, Gutierrez, and Flores 2017). Compared with working-class parents, upper- and middle-class parents are found more likely to choose schools that offer abundant curricula in languages, music, art and sport and talent programmes to improve their children's cultural capital for obtaining upper- or middle-class careers and lifestyles (Bereményi and Carrasco 2018; Smala, Paz, and Lingard 2013).

Social capital, i.e. family's social connections and networks, also affects likelihood of success in school choice. Studies conducted in the United Kingdom and the United States have shown that middle-class parents can obtain intimate knowledge and information from their large and higher status social circles to increase their children's success in the education market (Ball 2003; Bell 2009). In contrast, working-class parents lack the effective social networks through which to obtain accurate data (such as class sizes and test scores) that are important for school choice, thus restricting their children to a limited number of schools (Alegre and Benito 2012).

The literature suggests that school choice is a socially stratified practice with its outcomes largely influenced by family economic, social and cultural capital. Children from wealthier families are more likely to enrol in high-performing schools, leaving children from working-class or poor families concentrated in struggling schools (Bell 2009). School choice is therefore likely to deepen the social divide among schools and reinforce class inequality (Ball 2003).

Peidu, the rural school choice in China, exhibits similar inclination in class stratification since studying and living in county capitals obviously engender extra costs. However, unlike school choice in other parts of the world, *peidu* in China is not prompted by a market-driven educational policy. Instead, it is induced by the state-led social engineering of urbanisation.

School choice in rural China: *Peidu* for urbanisation

Unlike the market-based reform of school choice in international background, school choice during the compulsory education period is not permitted by the Chinese government. Under the national policy, Chinese children are required to attend neighbourhood schools according to residence registration, i.e. the widely known *hukou* system (National People's Congress 1986). Since implementation in 1950s, the *hukou* system has restricted rural-urban migration and secured a rural-urban segregation in job opportunities and welfare service (education included) for decades (Lin 2006). In the early years, the *hukou* system used to be an insurmountable barrier for rural children to attend urban public schools. However, in 2014, a *hukou* reform was launched by the Chinese government to allow migrants to obtain a local *hukou* in all but a few of the country's megacities (China's State Council 2014). The purpose of the reform was to promote the new urbanisation, which aims at reducing rural population and turning them into urban residents (Zhan 2017).

Hukou still matters, but its importance varies tremendously among different levels of urbanities. Megacities like Beijing and Shanghai continue with harsh controls over household registration. A variety of 'point systems' (*jifenzhi*) are introduced to evaluate qualifications of applicants for local *hukou*, which implicitly favour the middle- or upper-classes with higher education and stable employment and put rural migrants in disadvantage (Chen and Wang 2021; Wan and Vickers 2022). In other words, the role of *hukou* in population control has changed. In megacities, the rural population is subject to dual discrimination, overt discrimination by *hukou* status and tacit discrimination by socioeconomic standing. On the contrary, small cities welcome the rural population and thresholds to access local urban *hukou* are much lower. Public facilities such as schools, hospitals, libraries, etc. are open to residents in small cities disregarding the *hukou* status. For the rural population, access to quality public facilities in small cities depends more on the affordability of urban living than on *hukou* registration.

This change of *hukou* policy has reshaped the educational landscape of the rural population. On the one hand, rural migrant workers, shut out by public schools in large metropolis, decide to send their children back to small cities (county capitals) in their birth province, where quality public schools welcome them (Han and Yu 2020). On the other hand, rural left-behind children also flock into county capitals because of rural school consolidation and expansion of urban schools in the county. Rural population rapidly

concentrates in county urban districts; education becomes a tool to achieve the goal of urbanisation.

Rural school consolidation started in early 2000s and has resulted in massive closure of rural primary schools. From 2000 to 2022, the number of rural primary schools decreased by 83% from 440,284 to 76,093 (Ministry of Education 2022). Rural children were often assigned to nearby township schools, most of which were far from students' homes and poor in academic performance. Some better-off rural families abandoned township schools and found ways to enter county capital schools, triggering the *peidu* trend (Chen and Liang 2015; Pang et al. 2017).

Earlier school consolidation might be stimulated by concerns about resource efficiency. However, soon local governments realised that the influx of these better-off *peidu* families benefits the urbanisation of small cities. Both Ye (2017) and Zhang (2019) argued that the mass closure of rural schools was intentionally conducted by the local government to push rural people into small cities. Meanwhile, education parks were established in county capitals to accommodate rural students (Zhang 2019). Rural school closure coupled with expansion of county urban schools became an important strategy to achieve the urbanisation goal in small cities since one child studying in urban schools would bring at least one adult or even the whole family into the city (Hillman 2013; Zhang 2019). For example, the officials in Dapu, Guangdong province, strongly embraced the strategy in the remark that 'To develop Dapu, you should bring all rural children into the county capital' (Zhang 2019, 71). Urbanisation by concentration of schools has become the template for local governments and is supported by the central government's policy where it clearly states that 'school consolidation should be in coordinated with the urbanisation plan' (China's State Council 2001).

From the perspective of rural families, the urbanisation strategy has opened the window for school choice. Rural children with means now have the opportunity to enter county capital schools where subjects are offered in full, school activities richer, and instructional quality higher (Wang et al. 2017; Zhang et al. 2018). Such school choice of rural population inevitably entails the phenomenon of *peidu* due to the vast space in rural areas that often makes daily home-school commute impossible.

Apparently, *peidu*, school choice in rural China, takes place in an entirely different policy context from that documented in the international literature. It is urbanisation rather than marketisation that drives school choice in rural China. Despite the radically different rationale, policymakers in both contexts are similar in taking faith in the program for addressing the inequality issues. In the West, market competition is believed to be a silver bullet to boost quality of low-performing schools (Chubb and Moe 1990; Friedman 1962). Similarly, in China government officials believe that urbanisation of education reduces rural-urban inequality because rural students can enjoy an equal start by enrolling in better urban schools (Zhang 2019). However, the international literature has reminded us that school choice is a socially stratified practice and tends to reinforce inequality among schools (Ball 2003; Bell 2009). We suspect that similar outcomes may arise in rural China, where *peidu* draws away more affluent rural families, plunging rural schools into deeper crises. Empirical research on this topic is scarce if not entirely absent. This study aims to fill in this gap by examining *peidu* in relation to rural social stratification and exploring the consequences of *peidu* on rural schools.

Data from County G

County G is located in Hubei province of central China, with a population of 358,109 in 2018, 75% of whom were rural residents (Prefecture City Statistics Bureau 2019). School choice is widespread in County G (Prefecture City Evening News 2014), making the *peidu* phenomenon in this county typical of rural China.

The study focuses on primary schools. Migration for school choice, or *peidu* is more common at the primary school level, compared with later school levels, because children of this age need more care. In 2018, twelve primary schools were selected to participate upon their principals' acceptance. The selected schools comprised all three public schools in the county capital, three in townships and six village schools (five full-grade schools and one teaching point) spread across the three towns. We revisited the field site in 2023, and included in the sample the fourth public school in the county capital, which was newly established in 2021 to offer more places for the increasing *peidu* children. Township schools were included because rural children were often assigned to township schools when village schools were closed down. Township schools were usually considered better than village schools but inferior to county capital schools.

Teachers were recruited from the selected schools on a voluntary basis. With teachers' help and through snowball sampling, three groups of rural families were then selected: *peidu* families in the county capital, *peidu* families in townships and non-*peidu* families in villages. Qualitative and quantitative data were collected from questionnaires and interviews, supplemented by information from school archives. Table 1 provides the sample information.

Peidu in County G: school choice under urbanisation

One conspicuous outcome of *peidu* was large size of the urban schools (Table 2). The original six urban schools in this study had student enrolment ranging from over 700 students

Table 1. Information about research participants.

	Participants	No. of interviewees	No. of questionnaire respondents
<i>Peidu</i> families in the county capital	Father	1	21
	Mother	43	169
	Grandparents	21	161
	Other relatives	0	2
	Total	65	353
<i>Peidu</i> families in the townships	Father	3	4
	Mother	9	37
	Grandparents	23	99
	Other relatives	0	1
	Total	35	141
Total		83	494
Non- <i>peidu</i> families in villages	Father	7	71
	Mother	15	87
	Grandparents	23	155
	Other relatives	0	7
	Total	45	320
Teachers, principals and educational officials	Rural teachers and principals	39	50
	Urban teachers and principals	56	254
	Educational officials	8	N/A

Table 2. Rural students from outside catchment areas enrolled in urban schools in the 2017/2018 academic year.

School location	School	No. of students	Rural students from outside school district	
			No.	Percentage
County capital	School 1	2794	1508	54.0%
	School 2	1803	1485	82.3%
	School 3	815	693	85.0%
	Total	5412	3686	68.1%
Township	School 4	2435	1203	49.4%
	School 5	1455	552	37.9%
	School 6	712	215	30.2%
	Total	4602	1970	42.8%

to almost 2800 in the 2017/2018 academic year. Rural students from outside the schools' districts accounted for 68% of the total population of students in the county capital schools. In township schools, the number was 43%.

In contrast, rural schools were small (Table 3), with student populations ranging from 12 to 272 students in the 2017/2018 academic year. On average, only 27% of the school-aged children in the schools' catchment areas were enrolled in the sampled rural schools. According to rural teachers and principals, the proportion of relocated students enrolled in the urban schools within the county was 40%–60% in the academic years 2017/2018 (see Table A in Supplementary Materials).

The local government encouraged the *peidu* trend by building new schools in the county capital. School 3 and School X, newly established in 2016 and 2021 respectively, were specifically for enrolling and attracting rural students. As the vice director of the Education Bureau of County G stated:

Peidu leads to the large class and school sizes for urban schools ... Therefore, we have newly established School 3 in the county seat in 2016. Moreover, we plan to build another public school [School X] in the county seat to accommodate the increasing rural students. (O-Gong)

The new School X, which was opened in 2021, already enrolled 556 students in the 2022/2023 academic year, and approximately 95% of the students were rural children from villages. School X welcomed all students in the county with no requirements on *hukou* or school choice fee for admission, as confirmed by its principal. This indicates that the local government has temporarily suspended the discriminatory *hukou* system to attract rural households into the county capital.

Table 3. Number of students in rural schools in the 2017/2018 academic year.

Academic year	School	No. of students	No. of school-aged children in catchment area		Grades	Distance from county capital	Distance from township
				Percentage			
2017/2018	School 7	272	513	53.0%	1–6	66.1 km	11.0 km
	School 8	148	595	24.9%	1–6	15 km	13 km
	School 9	99	635	15.6%	1–6	72.2 km	13.7 km
	School 10	71	240	29.6%	Preschool, 1, 3, 4, 6	58.0 km	13.1 km
	School 11	65	431	15.1%	Preschool–6	24.8 km	12.9 km
	School 12	12	47	25.5%	Preschool–2	35.8 km	11.2 km
	Total	667	2461	27.1%	N/A	N/A	N/A

Meanwhile, the local government actively shut down more small-scale village schools. For instance, Village School 8 in our sample was closed by the government in 2022, and most of the students were assigned to School X. The government openly admits and promotes the school-closure-for-urbanisation strategy because it is believed to be a beneficial cause for rural families:

The government encourages rural residents to move to urban areas ... Through *peidu*, they can easily come to urban areas. Our county seat is expanding. Education should meet the needs of urbanisation and establish more schools for those coming to urban areas. (O-Gong, the vice director of the local Education Bureau)

We told the parents in School 8 about the advantages of the new county seat school [School X]. Teacher quality of the new school is much better than School 8. The parents were happy that School 8 was closed so their children can study in a better school. (O-Long)

Indeed, school quality was the top reason for *peidu*. 72% of *peidu* families in our questionnaire survey selected 'education quality' as the reason for relocation (82% of *peidu* families in the county capital and 48% of those in the townships). Five out of 100 interviewed *peidu* adults even transferred their children from poor-performing schools in large cities like Shenzhen to the county capital school in County G. This move came as their children were excluded from reputable public schools in megacities. Due to the long home-school distance, coupled with the absence of a school bus or boarding service, almost all rural families who opt for urban schools arrange for one adult to accompany their children. The mothers or grandparents usually became *peidu* adults, while the father or in many cases both the parents worked as migrant workers in large cities to support the living expenses. The questionnaire indicated that mothers and grandparents accounted for 42% (206) and 53% (260) of the 494 *peidu* adults, respectively.

Nevertheless, not all rural children could enjoy this newly granted privilege. Although the restriction on household registration (*hukou*) is relaxed, access to urban schools hinges more on family capital. It is especially so if one would like to enter the elite urban school (key school). Thus the urbanisation project tends to attract into urban areas rural families with higher financial and social resources, as the next section will show.

***Peidu* and rural social stratification**

Echoing the international literature, *peidu* as school choice was also found to be a socially stratified practice in County G. Family's economic and social capital played pivotal roles in determining if and where to *peidu*. In general, *peidu* families in the county capital possessed more resources than those in township schools, leaving the most needy families in village schools.

Economic capital

A significant financial investment was necessary to accompany children in the county capital or township, to cover rent, daily living expenses and, in some cases, extracurricular tutoring.

Housing was one of the most important costs for *peidu* families, with an average annual rent in 2018 of RMB4,035 in the county capital and RMB2,133 in the townships. Apart from

housing, the annual expenditure on food and necessities averaged RMB17,290 for the *peidu* families in the county capital and RMB10,500 for those in townships. In total, the mean annual cost in 2018 was RMB21,325 for a *peidu* family in the county capital and RMB12,633 for a *peidu* family in townships (see Figure 1 in Supplementary Materials). When we revisit County G in 2023, the annual rent increased to a minimum of RMB7,000 in the county capital.

The questionnaire data revealed that 49% of *peidu* families in the county capital and 17% of those in the townships sent their children to extracurricular classes. Specifically, 29% of *peidu* families in the county capital and 15% of those in the townships sent their children to academic tutoring to help their children finish homework and improve academic performance. The cost for one academic tutoring for one semester ranged from RMB1,000 to RMB2,000 in the county capital and from RMB600 to RMB1,200 in the townships. *Peidu* parents in the county capital, especially the young and better educated ones, also put children in non-academic after-school classes. These *peidu* adults had already subscribed to the middle-class concept of ‘whole-person development’ and were willing to make investment in their children. According to the questionnaire survey, 30% of *peidu* adults in the county capital had enrolled their children in hobby classes, such as drawing and dance, whereas only four of the 141 *peidu* adults in the townships and none in the village had done so. The cost for one hobby class was between RMB1,200 and RMB2,800 per semester. A few *peidu* adults sent their children to two or more hobby classes. For example, S-Lirui’s mother chose three interest classes including basketball, table tennis and swimming for her son, costing a total of around RMB3000 one semester. This family also sent the child to the English tutoring class, costing RMB1500 half a year. Thus, the total cost on extracurricular classes for this family reached to RMB9000 every year.

In contrast, the average annual income of rural residents in County G was merely RMB10,340 per capita in 2018, inclusive of remittances from migrant workers in large cities (Prefecture City Statistics Bureau 2019). Therefore, the high cost of urban living and extracurricular classes was a deterrent for poor rural families choosing schools in townships and the county capital. The questionnaire data supported this, showing that financial stringency had impeded 60% of rural non-*peidu* families from choosing an urban school. Evidently, the impoverished rural families had no choice but to accept the village schools.

Social capital

Economic capital decided if *peidu* would be financially viable for rural families to live in urban districts, but social capital played a vital role in the choice of schools. Most rural school choice took place within the public school system with free tuition so the financial barrier to access urban schools was low. Nonetheless, the quality of public schools also varied, with the prestigious key school (School 1) being much more selective than the recently built Schools 3 and X. Hence, which urban school *peidu* children could enter heavily depended on family’s social connections.

In the county capital, forty-two of the 48 interviewed *peidu* families from School 1, 2 and 3 had mobilised their social connections with target school staff for accessing their desired schools. For the choice of township school, 16 of the 22 interviewed families

from Schools 4 and 5 had utilised social capital for school admissions. The necessity of social capital for choosing a school of better reputation was confirmed by non-*peidu* adults. For example, three non-*peidu* grandmothers and one mother had tried to send their children to School 4 and School 5, but had been rejected due to their lack of ties with the school staff.

Strength of social ties with the targeted urban schools mattered most. Direct ties with principals or teaching staff in targeted schools were often stronger and more effective. Of the 58 adults (42 in the county capital and 16 in townships) who made use of social networks, 36 (24 in the county capital and 12 in the townships) achieved success in their school choice through a direct connection to relatives (29), former classmates (6) or former colleagues (1) teaching at their target schools.

My aunt-in-law teaches at School 2. I told her that I wanted to send my son to the county capital school in the summer holiday and asked her for help. Before the registration day, she told me to register the next day. Then I successfully chose School 2 for my son. It was easy. (S-Jun's mother)

Indirect ties could work as well. Another 14 *peidu* families (12 in the county capital and two in the townships) who had relatives or friends who happened to know the administrative staff in the target schools also managed to win the school places for their children.

However, only families with strong and powerful connections could secure a school place in the most selective, prestigious School 1. For instance, a direct tie with a distant relative teaching in School 1 might not be considered strong enough. Teacher Cheng in School 1 was begged by one of her distant relatives for admission into School 1. She told us that 'I did not want to trouble my principal ... [because] the child was not my nephew or niece'. So she referred the child to the vice-principal of School 2, a non-key school where the child was accepted.

In contrast, an indirect tie through a powerful intermediary with a wide network of authorities was perceived to be most effective. For example, a *peidu* parent in School 1 stated:

My elder brother works in the Forestry Bureau. He knows many people including the principal of School 1. Before the summer break I told him that I wanted to choose School 1 for my son. Then my son was admitted into School 1. (S-Ke's mother)

Social connections like in this case with public sector employees or authorities were considered strong and powerful enough to secure a place in the renowned School 1 in the county capital, as confirmed by both teachers and *peidu* parents.

Obviously, rural families with different social circles were stratified along the varied qualities of schools. Families well connected with powerful authorities were likely concentrated in the most selective key school, while others with some social ties were streamed into less reputable urban schools, leaving behind the families without financial means or social capital in least desired township or village schools.

Verification of family capital effects

The above findings from interviews were further verified with statistical models drawing from the questionnaire data. First, a comparison of family socioeconomic status (SES) was

conducted among the three groups: *peidu* families in the county capital, *peidu* families in townships, and non-*peidu* families. Family SES was a composite index measured by family income, highest education level and highest occupational status of parents. The findings confirmed that *peidu* families overall had a significantly higher SES score ($n = 494$, $M = 0.181$, $SD = 0.961$) than non-*peidu* families ($n = 320$, $M = -0.279$, $SD = 0.996$), $t(812) = 6.566$, $p < 0.001$. More nuanced comparison of the three groups showed that the *peidu* families in the county capital ($n = 353$, $M = 0.280$, $SD = 0.982$) had a higher SES than those in the townships ($n = 141$, $M = -0.069$, $SD = 0.861$), $t(492) = 3.690$, $p < 0.001$, who in turn had a higher SES than the non-*peidu* families in villages, $t(459) = 2.172$, $p < 0.05$. Also, the *peidu* families with children attending the top school, School 1 ($n = 167$, $M = 0.572$, $SD = 0.984$), had a significantly higher SES than those with children attending non-key schools in the county capital ($n = 186$, $M = 0.018$, $SD = 0.906$), $t(351) = 5.506$, $p < 0.001$. The comparisons depicted the ladder of social strata in the *peidu* phenomenon: family SES in the key school > in non-key schools in the county capital > in township schools > in village schools (see Figure 2 in Supplementary Materials).

Second, binary logistic regression models were run to specify the effects of family capital on rural parents' school choice (see Table 4). Model 1 compared *peidu* families with non-*peidu* families. It found that *peidu* families tended to have a higher annual income (over RMB80,000), higher parental education (post-compulsory level), higher occupational status (non-farming), and more social connections with public sector employees.

Model 2 compared *peidu* families in the townships with those in the county capital. Compared with Model 1, the effects of income and occupational status were muted. Instead, cultural (education) and social capital were most important in accessing county capital schools.

Model 3 predicted the probability of getting into the key primary school for the *peidu* families in the county capital. Again, family income, parents' post-compulsory education and social connections all exhibited significant effects.

Interestingly, parental cultural knowledge was not found to be a decisive factor in the rural school choice process, contrary to its influential role identified in the international literature (Bereményi and Carrasco 2018). Neither did the interviewees mention knowledge about school preferences, school interview skills, or personal tastes in the school selection process. There were possibly two reasons. For one, the school admission process was simple, as it did not involve interview or other evaluative measures. Therefore, subtle cultural know-how was unnecessary for entering schools in the county capital. Secondly, the ranking of all the four public schools in the county capital was transparent information known to all. Hence, rural parents did not need complex cultural knowledge to distinguish among schools. The different outcomes of school choice were less a result from disparity in cultural knowledge, but were instead influenced by the varying strengthen of social connections.

In summary, *peidu*, or rural school choice, was highly contingent on family socioeconomic standing. The rural families with the highest SES chose a quality school in the county capital or even the best school in the county for their children, the middle socioeconomic group chose township schools, while the children of the most disadvantaged languished in impoverished rural schools. As a result, rural schools suffered the loss of families with valuable economic, cultural and social resources.

Table 4. Factors influencing rural parents' exercise of school choice.

	Model 1 <i>Peidu</i> vs non- <i>peidu</i> (<i>n</i> = 814)		Model 2 <i>Peidu</i> in county capital vs <i>peidu</i> in townships (<i>n</i> = 494)		Model 3 Key school vs other schools in country capital (<i>n</i> = 353)	
	Coef. (SE)	Exp (B)	Coef. (SE)	Exp (B)	Coef. (SE)	Exp (B)
Constant	−0.643 (0.517)	0.214	1.679* (0.844)	5.361	−1.344 (1.037)	0.261
Family annual income (ref. = under RMB40,000)						
RMB40,000–80,000	0.404 (0.258)	1.498	−0.642 (0.410)	0.526	1.570** (0.455)	4.808
Over RMB80,000	0.706* (0.322)	2.025	−0.355 (0.484)	0.701	1.832*** (0.501)	6.245
Highest occupational status of parents (ref. = no job and farmers)						
Local worker	0.949* (0.404)	2.584	0.742 (0.707)	2.100	−0.183 (0.829)	0.833
Migrant worker	1.021* (0.394)	2.775	−0.406 (0.679)	0.667	−0.689 (0.820)	0.502
Businessman, professional, village cadre and official	1.075* (0.465)	2.929	0.556 (0.775)	1.744	−0.106 (0.868)	1.112
Highest educational level of parents (ref. = illiterate and primary school)						
Junior middle school	0.201 (0.183)	1.233	0.475 (0.262)	1.608	0.300 (0.324)	1.350
High school and above	0.876** (0.257)	2.402	1.155** (0.353)	3.175	1.024** (0.368)	2.784
Social connections ^a	1.218*** (0.164)	3.380	1.455*** (0.241)	4.286	0.962** (0.289)	2.617
Female	−0.341* (0.162)	0.711	−0.264 (0.233)	0.768	−0.584* (0.243)	0.557
One-parent family	−0.198 (0.299)	0.820	−0.965* (0.429)	0.381	0.595 (0.514)	1.814
Number of children	−0.654*** (0.153)	0.520	−0.429 (0.2270)	0.651	−0.499* (0.236)	0.607
Distance from rural school (≥ 6 km) ^b	0.987*** (0.184)	2.684	−1.160*** (0.236)	0.314	0.587* (0.268)	1.799
−2 log likelihood	926.864		474.142		425.835	
Model χ^2	164.097***		116.686***		62.504***	
Pseudo R^2	0.247		0.302		0.217	

^aThe variable 'social connections' refers to whether the rural families had relatives or friends who were public sector employees or authorities in the county capital or townships.

^bIt takes a pupil around 90 min or more to walk to a school that is 6 km or further from their homes.

Note: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Impact of rural parental school choice on rural schools

Similar with the findings in international literature, *peidu*, parental school choice in rural China, took away the cream of the crop and left the rural school in deeper struggles. Losing 40%–60% of the students to urban schools, village schools ran into crisis in all fronts, including funding, staffing and class instruction.

First, since school funding was determined based on the number of enrolled students, any decline in student enrolment significantly reduced the financial and physical resources allotted to rural schools.

We have only 49 primary school students [other 16 are preschool students]. The funding is allocated based on RMB650 per student every academic year. Thus, we don't have enough funding. The electricity even costs more than RMB2,000 a month. Our school still has debts. A lot of the teaching equipment is broken and we have no money to pay for repairs. (P-Yao)

Educational officers confirmed that the government prioritised the resource allocation for large schools. Rural schools with shrinking scales were positioned at disadvantage.

Second, the continual loss of students increased teacher turnover in rural schools. The expansion of urban schools to accommodate the influx of rural *peidu* students created a surge of demand for teachers. The vacancies in the new urban schools were usually filled by young and capable teachers from township and village schools. This resulted in a loss of quality teachers in rural schools, just as T-Jiang said, 'In recent years, teachers who can and want to transfer to urban areas all have gone. Only the old teachers stay'. Meanwhile, the plummeting enrolment also made the government reluctant to assign new teachers to village schools, as confirmed by all six rural principals.

My school has not received any new teachers in 5 to 6 years, but three teachers have retired in the past 5 years. No new teachers were assigned to our school to replace the retired teachers. Why? Because our school size is decreasing and they [the government] think that it is not worth allocating teachers to our school. (T-Wang)

Third, the loss of positive peers and the tiny class sizes due to *peidu* impeded rural schools' teaching and learning. According to 83% of rural teachers who participated in our survey, students who opted to leave rural schools typically exhibited superior academic performance and behaviour compared to those who stayed. The mini class size also dampened teachers' enthusiasm in teaching, because 'no students respond to me' (T-Tian) and 'the reading voice is too low, resulting in a bad teaching climate' (T-Hu). Moreover, the loss of students hindered the implementation of classroom activities, because 'it was difficult to organise group discussion with a total of five students in the class' (T-Hu). Also, the loss of positive peers lowered students' sense of competitiveness and weakened students' motivation for learning, according to Principal of School 9. Eleven teachers indicated that the learning environment in rural schools had deteriorated following the advent of *peidu*, consequently impacting students' academic performance negatively.

Worse still, the outflow of children and of teachers coupled by the subpar academic performance led to diminishing trust in rural schools among rural parents, resulting in more families leaving for urban schools. This distrust perpetuated the notion that rural schools were irredeemable and that urbanisation was the sole viable solution for rural education. Consequently, the remaining rural schools were caught in a vicious cycle, heightening the risk of school closures with each leaving child. Left behind families in rural schools suffered from anxiety about their future. One grandfather in a village school complained:

Most children in our village are studying in urban schools. There are only a few students in this school now ... If the school is closed, it will be difficult for the remaining children to go to school. The rich can send their children to the township. The poor will be deprived of education. (S-Hao's grandfather)

Ultimately it was the most disadvantaged families low in both financial and social capital who bore the brunt of consequences stemming from the socially stratified *peidu* trend.

Discussion and conclusion

This study confirms that the prevalent trend of *peidu* in rural China represents a form of school choice exercised by rural parents. Rural families abandon village schools and move

children into urban schools in the county for better academic achievement. However, the policy background of this rural school choice is markedly distinct from that found in the international literature. While in the West and in some other developing countries school choice of various types is often driven by market-oriented reforms (Adnett and Davies 2003; Cookson and Shapira 1997), in China the upsurge of rural school choice has been a component of the government's urbanisation strategy.

The case of County G replicates the urbanisation model already implemented in other parts of China (see Zhang 2019), using schools to entice rural families into urban districts, especially the county capital, to fuel urban economy and increase urban population. The closing of village schools together with the expansion of urban schools creates a push–pull dynamic that drives rural families to relocate to urban areas. Similar to proponents who argue that market-driven school choice programs can alleviate educational inequality, local officials in China also regard urbanisation as a solution to rural-urban disparities. Findings from the current study, however, cast doubt on this claim.

Although emerged in different contexts, *peidu*, the school choice in rural China, is also a stratified practice along class lines, similar to school choice in international contexts (Ball 2003; Debs and Cheung 2021). Rural households with best income, higher parental education, and strong social networks manage to obtain places in county capital schools, while the middle stratum of rural families choose township schools and the most disadvantaged families stranded in village schools. Access to urban schools in small cities is much less restricted by household registration (*hukou*) than by family socioeconomic status. The most affluent and well-connected families manage to secure admissions into elite key schools, while families in poverty are barred from urban schools because of the high cost of urban living. The administrative discrimination based on *hukou* is increasingly and implicitly being replaced by market discrimination based on family socioeconomic standings.

This stratified *peidu* phenomenon serves to correct the common urban stereotype that regards all rural population as poor and backward, ignorant about the diversity and differences among rural households. In fact, as the current research indicates, the rural population has developed considerable heterogeneity in socioeconomic conditions. Rural society has become increasingly differentiated with the rising market economy since China's reform and opening up (Zhang 2015). For example, the income of the top 20% of rural income earners was 8.2 times higher than that of the lowest 20% in 2012, with the gap having grown by 1.8 times since 1990 (Yan and Chen 2015). Blind to these nuanced inequalities within the rural society, the urbanisation project through schooling functions to further divide the rural society, defeating its goal of reducing rural-urban inequality.

Obviously, the relaxation on *hukou* status does not signal the end of discrimination. Rather, it shifts from identity-based to class-based discrimination. The 'visible hand' is replaced by the covert 'invisible hand' of the market to achieve population screening, which ultimately serves urban economic development (urbanisation).

As the result of *peidu*, the school system, like in other school choice programs, continues to be stratified by social class, hence unequal. Specifically, the inequality between rural and urban schools is not diminished but rather intensified by *peidu*, contrary to what urbanisation advocates argue. The departure of rural children subjects village schools to decreased funding, accelerated teacher turnover, worsening academic performance, and an ultimately increased risk of school closures. These findings confirm

the international literature that school choice is detrimental to disadvantaged schools, defeating its promise of educational equality (Ball 2003; Imberman 2011).

In conclusion, school choice, whether driven by marketisation or urbanisation, merely addresses the surface issues when it comes to educational inequality. The disparities among schools are rooted in the social stratification of school enrolment. Transferring the upper echelon of disadvantaged children and/or families to better schools does not reduce the privileges of elite schools or enhance the struggling ones; instead, it reinforces class-based stratification in education. Moreover, in the case of rural China, *peidu* goes beyond choice of schools and also involve considerable depopulation of rural communities (Wang and Teng 2022). Therefore, rural school choice in China not only jeopardises the well-being of rural schools, but also poses a threat to the sustainability of agriculture and the rural society as a whole. These negative impacts call for an urgent reassessment of China's current urbanisation strategy in small cities, particularly regarding its manipulation of schools to encourage *peidu*, i.e. the rural school choice.

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